

OKAFOR FAMILY STORIES

Papa’s Machine

Family Conversation Guide

Before you begin

Papa’s Machine is a short, fictional drama from Okafor Family Stories, set in contemporary Nigeria. This guide is for families, church and community groups, and writers who want to talk about what the story brings up. **It reveals the ending, so watch the film first.** Watch it together, pause for a moment of quiet, then choose the questions that fit your group. You do not need to answer all eight.

The story in brief

Ngozi, a young banker based in Lagos, comes home to Enugu and finds her mother, Mama Ifeoma, selling her late father’s Singer sewing machine to a buyer, Bayo. Ngozi is shocked and hurt: the machine was Papa’s, and it has sat at the heart of the family home for years. The two women face each other, each sure she knows what the other is thinking. Then the truth comes out. Mama is selling the machine to help pay for Ngozi’s *igba nkwu*, the traditional Igbo wedding ceremony planned for December. She will sew Ngozi’s outfit herself, on the machine, before it leaves. A sacrifice made quietly, and a love that nearly went unspoken.

Eight questions to talk about

1 SACRIFICE

Mama chose to give up something precious without telling her daughter. When is a quiet sacrifice an act of love, and when might it leave the other person feeling shut out?

2 SACRIFICE

What is something a parent, grandparent or elder gave up for you that you only understood later? How did you learn about it?

3 COMMUNICATION

Ngozi and Mama each assumed the worst about the other for a few tense moments. What could either of them have said or asked first? What helps you pause before reacting?

4 TRADITION

The *igba nkwu* is an important moment for many Igbo families. What does a ceremony like this mean to you, and who carries the work of making it happen in your family?

5 TRADITION

Mama chose to make the outfit with her own hands. What can handmade or inherited things say that money cannot? What objects hold your family together?

6 MONEY

Should a parent’s money be spent on a child’s wedding if it costs the parent something important? Where would you draw the line, and who should help decide?

7 HONESTY

Mama kept the reason private to protect the surprise, or perhaps her daughter’s pride. Is withholding the same as lying? When does protecting someone become hiding from them?

8 BETWEEN GENERATIONS

How do your parents’ or your children’s ideas about money, duty and showing love differ from your own? Share one thing you would like the other generation to understand.

Try this at home: the Thank-You Thread

A gentle exercise for two people (parent and adult child, grandparent and grandchild, or any pair who want to say more than they usually do). Allow about 20 minutes and a pot of tea or a cold drink.

1. **Choose an object.** Each person brings one item that holds a memory of the other's care: a cloth, a tool, a recipe card, a photograph, a pot.
2. **Tell its story.** Take turns, two minutes each, saying where the object came from and what it cost the giver, in time, effort or money, as far as you know.
3. **Say one thank-you you have never said.** Keep it small and specific: "I remember when you… and I never thanked you." The listener answers only with "Thank you for telling me."
4. **Ask one gentle question.** "Is there something you are carrying that I could help with?" You are free to say "not today." That is an answer too.
5. **Close with a small act.** Share a meal, mend something together, or write the date and one line on the back of the object.

Tips for different groups

Families. Keep it voluntary. Elders may prefer to listen first. Let younger members choose which question to start with, and keep phones away for the conversation.

Church and community groups. Use two or three questions in small circles of four to six people, then invite one volunteer per circle to share a thought with the whole group. Agree beforehand that personal stories stay in the room.

Writers and storytellers. Ask: what does each character want, and what are they afraid to say? Rewrite the confrontation so Mama explains early, then compare how the scene changes. Where does tension come from when the truth is already known?

> **A note on care.** Conversations about money, grief and family expectations can touch tender places. If a topic is too heavy, skip it. If a family disagreement or bereavement needs more support than a conversation can give, consider speaking with a trusted elder, pastor, counsellor or other qualified professional.

About this guide. Okafor Family Stories makes short, original Nigerian family dramas. All stories and characters are fictional and created with AI video tools; any resemblance to real people is coincidental. This guide is free to share and print for personal, family, church and classroom use. Please keep this page and credit "Okafor Family Stories". Feedback and collaboration: pnsgloballlc@gmail.com.